

March 26, 2026

Vertex Pharmaceuticals Incorporated

HORIZON Data Supports APOL1 Inhibition in FSGS; Focus on Efficacy in Broader AMKD Ahead of AMPLITUDE Data Late 2026/2027

Before the market open on Wednesday, March 25, Maze Therapeutics (MAZE \$31.73) announced top-line data from the Phase II HORIZON trial of MZE829, a dual-mechanism APOL1 inhibitor in APOL1-mediated kidney disease (AMKD). Maze shares traded down 35% due to reduced proteinuria efficacy in non-FSGS patients despite the FSGS patient data comparing well to Vertex's inaxaplin Phase IIa study in FSGS patients only. Treatment with MZE829 250mg for 12 weeks resulted in 31%, 46%, and 59% improvements in proteinuria (uPCR) when adjusting for patient non-compliance in broad AMKD (n=12), patients without diabetes (n=7), and patients with FSGS (n=4), respectively. Although cross-trial comparison caveats apply, Vertex's inaxaplin showed a 47.6% improvement in uPCR in FSGS patients (n=12) at week 13 ([Egbuna O et al., 2023. NEJM](#)).

Despite very small patient numbers that make it difficult to conclude any superiority here, the FSGS proteinuria improvement is impressive for oral molecules across both programs. However, the reduced efficacy in broader AMKD patients observed in the HORIZON study has raised investor concerns over the magnitude of efficacy to be expected by APOL1 inhibition beyond those with FSGS, which is a smaller fragment of the potential AMKD market. Indeed, the APOL1 genotype-mediated risk for FSGS onset (15- to 20-fold) appears greater than that for non-diabetic chronic kidney disease (7- to 10-fold; [Pollack MR et al., 2023. Glomerular Dis](#)), which may imply differential efficacy of APOL1 inhibitors across populations, but it remains difficult to interpret small patient numbers here. Vertex is enrolling a broader APOL1 mutant, non-diabetic, proteinuric kidney disease population in the ongoing Phase II/III AMPLITUDE study and an interim 48-week eGFR-based readout is expected, potentially in late 2026. Given reduced proteinuria efficacy observed in the broader AMKD population relative to those with FSGS in HORIZON, there will be debate over whether this will also be observed in AMPLITUDE.

Vertex is a biopharma company focused on the development and commercialization of transformative specialty medicines for the treatment of cystic fibrosis and other rare genetic diseases.

Please refer to important disclosures on pages 3 – 4. Analyst certification is on page 3.

William Blair or an affiliate does and seeks to do business with companies covered in its research reports. As a result, investors should be aware that the firm may have a conflict of interest that could affect the objectivity of this report. This report is not intended to provide personal investment advice. The opinions and recommendations herein do not take into account individual client circumstances, objectives, or needs and are not intended as recommendations of particular securities, financial instruments, or strategies to particular clients. The recipient of this report must make its own independent decisions regarding any securities or financial instruments mentioned herein.

William Blair

Myles R. Minter, Ph.D. +1 617 235 7534
mminter@williamblair.com

John Boyle, Ph.D. +1 212 245 6509
jboyle@williamblair.com

Jake Batchelder, Ph.D. +1 332 262 2602
jbatchelder@williamblair.com

Stock Rating:

Outperform

Symbol: VRTX (NASDAQ)
Price: \$454.97 (52-Wk.: \$363-\$511)
Market Value (M): \$115,755
Dividend/Yield: \$0.00/0.00%
Fiscal Year End: December

	2025A	2026E	2027E
Estimates			
Sales (M) FY	\$12,001.2	\$13,029.6	\$13,798.0
EPS FY	\$15.32	\$17.36	\$16.44
Valuation			
EV/Sales	8.8x	8.1x	7.6x
FY P/E	29.7x	26.2x	27.7x

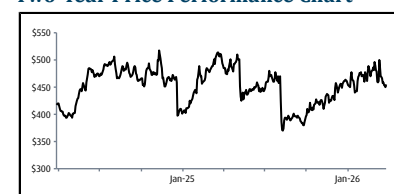
Trading Data (FactSet)

Shares Outstanding (M):	254.0
Float (M):	253.2
Avg. Daily Volume (90-day):	1,446,471

Financial Data (FactSet)

Book Value Per Share (MRQ):	\$73.49
Return on Equity (TTM):	22.5%
Enterprise Value (M):	\$105,072

Two-Year Price Performance Chart



Sources: FactSet, William Blair & Company estimates

One outstanding question overlooked by investors is how strongly AMKD patients, with FSGS or broader proteinuric kidney disease, actually follow kidney disease patient dynamics described in the RADAR study. Maze and other sponsors assume a $\geq 30\%$ improvement on uACR is clinically meaningful, correlated to eGFR slope improvement, and may result in a potential 10-year slowing of end-stage renal disease onset. In the Phase IIa inaxaplin publication, Vertex sets that bar at $\geq 40\%$ improvement in the discussion section. We raise this point because in IgAN, where patient trajectories described in RADAR have been deemed applicable by the FDA (accepting proteinuria as a surrogate endpoint for approval in IgAN but requiring eGFR for AMKD currently), Novartis's (NVS \$150.75) endothelin A receptor antagonist Vanrafia (atrasentan) narrowly missed on 2.5 year eGFR data despite showing 36% placebo-normalized proteinuria improvement at week 36 in a pivotal ALIGN study in IgAN patients ([Heerspink HJL et al., 2025. NEJM](#)). The longer-term question is whether a 31% proteinuria reduction seen with MZE829 in a broader AMKD population (and if inaxaplin shows reduced proteinuria lowering in non-FSGS patients) can really translate into reliable eGFR benefit in a shorter 48-week timeframe if this was not the case in a recent IgAN study? Obviously, we are extrapolating from very small datasets here, which carry many caveats.

We remain confident in inaxaplin's profile heading into the AMPLITUDE interim readout but acknowledge the broader patient population will fuel debate. We reiterate our Outperform rating on Vertex.

Vertex Valuation. We believe Trikafta's organic growth is durable, with IP supported through 2037, and Vertex maintains a competitive moat. Recent approval of the vanzacaftor triple combination (Alyftrek, vanzacaftor-tezacaftor-deutivacaftor), the company's next-generation CFTR modulator therapy, stands to extend peak branded CF revenues into the 2040s, which remains a major source of free cash flow for Vertex. With time, we should also see major contributions from Casgevy, Journavx, and the renal franchise. Vertex trades at a premium price-to-earnings ratio to peers, but we believe this is deserved, given our view that it is one of the highest-quality large-cap growth names in biotech.

Vertex Risks. Risks to our Outperform rating on Vertex are primarily clinical, regulatory, and commercial in nature, like other players Trikafta and Alyftrek. We also see risks associated with the launch of exa-cel and potential commercial reimbursement pressures for what will presumably be a pricey gene-edited cell-based therapeutic. For Journavx in pain, we see significant clinical risk associated with neuropathic indications, where trials have yielded promising results early on but have failed to see these translate into placebo-controlled efficacy in later stages.

IMPORTANT DISCLOSURES

William Blair or an affiliate is a market maker in the security of Vertex Pharmaceuticals Incorporated.

William Blair or an affiliate expects to receive or intends to seek compensation for investment banking services from Vertex Pharmaceuticals Incorporated or an affiliate within the next three months.

Officers and employees of William Blair or its affiliates (other than research analysts) may have a financial interest in the securities of Vertex Pharmaceuticals Incorporated.

This report is available in electronic form to registered users via R*Docs™ at <https://williamblairlibrary.bluematrix.com> or www.williamblair.com.

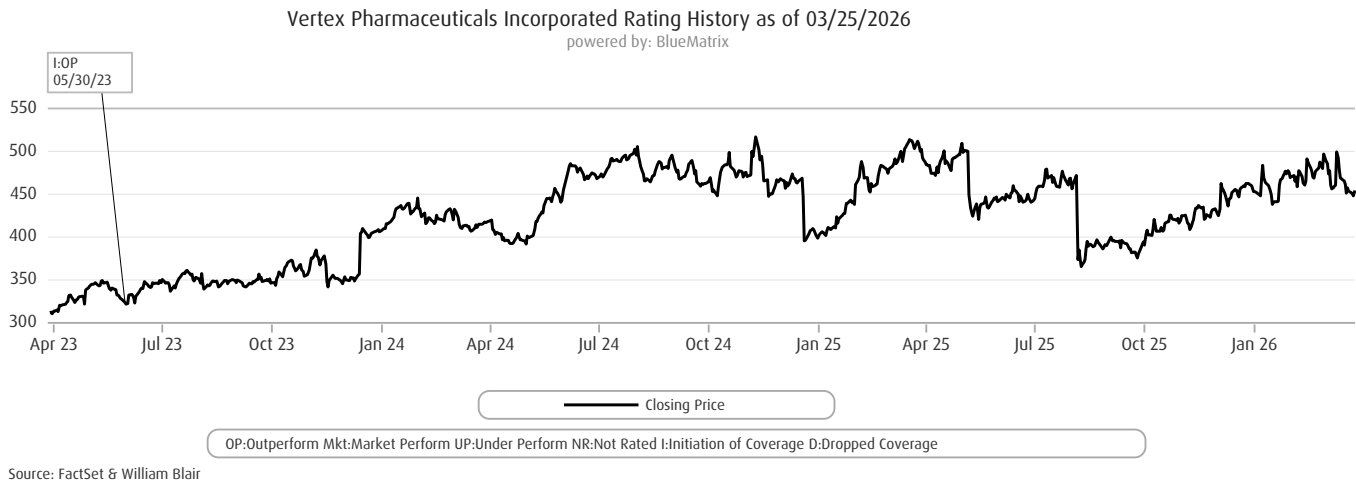
Please contact us at +1 312 236 1600 or consult <https://www.williamblair.com/equity-research/coverage> for all disclosures.

Myles R. Minter attests that 1) all of the views expressed in this research report accurately reflect his/her personal views about any and all of the securities and companies covered by this report, and 2) no part of his/her compensation was, is, or will be related, directly or indirectly, to the specific recommendations or views expressed by him/her in this report. We seek to update our research as appropriate. Other than certain periodical industry reports, the majority of reports are published at irregular intervals as deemed appropriate by the research analyst.

DOW JONES: 46124.10

S&P 500: 6556.37

NASDAQ: 21761.90



Additional information is available upon request.

Current Rating Distribution (as of March 25, 2026):

Coverage Universe	Percent	Inv. Banking Relationships *	Percent
Outperform (Buy)	73	Outperform (Buy)	13
Market Perform (Hold)	26	Market Perform (Hold)	2
Underperform (Sell)	1	Underperform (Sell)	0

*Percentage of companies in each rating category that are investment banking clients, defined as companies for which William Blair has received compensation for investment banking services within the past 12 months.

The compensation of the research analyst is based on a variety of factors, including performance of his or her stock recommendations; contributions to all of the firm's departments, including asset management, corporate finance, institutional sales, and retail brokerage; firm profitability; and competitive factors.

OTHER IMPORTANT DISCLOSURES

Stock ratings and valuation methodologies: William Blair & Company, L.L.C. uses a three-point system to rate stocks. Individual ratings reflect the expected performance of the stock relative to the broader market (generally the S&P 500, unless otherwise indicated) over the next 12 months. The assessment of expected performance is a function of near-, intermediate-, and long-term company fundamentals, industry outlook, confidence in earnings estimates, valuation (and our valuation methodology), and other factors. Outperform (O) - stock expected to outperform the broader market over the next 12 months; Market Perform (M) - stock expected to perform approximately in line with the broader market over the next 12 months; Underperform (U) - stock expected to underperform the broader market over the next 12 months; not rated (NR) - the stock is not currently rated. The valuation methodologies include (but are not limited to) price-to-earnings multiple (P/E), relative P/E (compared with the relevant market), P/E-to-growth-rate (PEG) ratio, market capitalization/revenue multiple, enterprise value/EBITDA ratio, discounted cash flow, and others. Stock ratings and valuation methodologies should not be used or relied upon as investment advice. Past performance is not necessarily a guide to future performance.

The ratings and valuation methodologies reflect the opinion of the individual analyst and are subject to change at any time.

Our salespeople, traders, and other professionals may provide oral or written market commentary, short-term trade ideas, or trading strategies to our clients, prospective clients, and our trading desks that are contrary to opinions expressed in this research report. Certain outstanding research reports may contain discussions or investment opinions relating to securities, financial instruments and/or issuers that are no longer current. Investing in securities involves risks. This report does not contain all the material information necessary for an investment decision. Always refer to the most recent report on a company or issuer. Our asset management and trading desks may make investment decisions that are inconsistent with recommendations or views expressed in this report. We will from time to time have long or short positions in, act as principal in, and buy or sell the securities referred to in this report. Our research is disseminated primarily electronically, and in some instances in printed form. Research is simultaneously available to all clients. This research report is for our clients only. No part of this material may be copied or duplicated in any form by any means or redistributed without the prior written consent of William Blair & Company, L.L.C.

This is not in any sense an offer or solicitation for the purchase or sale of a security or financial instrument.

The factual statements herein have been taken from sources we believe to be reliable, but such statements are made without any representation as to accuracy or completeness or otherwise, except with respect to any disclosures relative to William Blair or its research analysts. Opinions expressed are our own unless otherwise stated and are subject to change without notice. Prices shown are approximate.

This report or any portion hereof may not be copied, reprinted, sold, or redistributed or disclosed by the recipient to any third party, by content scraping or extraction, automated processing, or any other form or means, without the prior written consent of William Blair. Any unauthorized use is prohibited.

If the recipient received this research report pursuant to terms of service for, or a contract with William Blair for, the provision of research services for a separate fee, and in connection with the delivery of such research services we may be deemed to be acting as an investment adviser, then such investment adviser status relates, if at all, only to the recipient with whom we have contracted directly and does not extend beyond the delivery of this report (unless otherwise agreed specifically in writing). If such recipient uses these research services in connection with the sale or purchase of a security referred to herein, William Blair may act as principal for our own account or as riskless principal or agent for another party. William Blair is and continues to act solely as a broker-dealer in connection with the execution of any transactions, including transactions in any securities referred to herein.

For important disclosures, please visit our website at williamblair.com.

This material is distributed in the United Kingdom and the European Economic Area (EEA) by William Blair International, Ltd., authorised and regulated by the Financial Conduct Authority (FCA). William Blair International, Limited is a limited liability company registered in England and Wales with company number 03619027. This material is only directed and issued to persons regarded as Professional investors or equivalent in their home jurisdiction, or persons falling within articles 19 (5), 38, 47, and 49 of the Financial Services and Markets Act of 2000 (Financial Promotion) Order 2005 (all such persons being referred to as "relevant persons"). This document must not be acted on or relied on by persons who are not "relevant persons."

This report is being furnished in Brazil on a confidential basis and is addressed to the addressee personally, and for its sole benefit. This does not constitute an offer or solicitation for the purchase or sale of a security by any means that would constitute a public offering in Brazil under the regulations of the Brazilian Securities and Exchange Commission (*Comissão de Valores Mobiliários*) or an unauthorized distribution under Brazilian laws and regulations. The securities are authorized for trading on non-Brazilian securities markets, and this report and all the information herein is intended solely for professional investors (as defined by the applicable Brazilian regulation) who may only acquire these securities through a non-Brazilian account, with settlement outside Brazil in a non-Brazilian currency.

"William Blair" and "R*Docs" are registered trademarks of William Blair & Company, L.L.C. Copyright 2026, William Blair & Company, L.L.C. All rights reserved.

William Blair & Company, L.L.C. licenses and applies the SASB Materiality Map® and SICSTM in our work.

Equity Research Directory

John Kreger, Partner Director of Research +1 312 364 8612
Kyle Harris, CFA, Partner Operations Manager +1 312 364 8230

CONSUMER

Sharon Zackfia, CFA, Partner +1 312 364 5386
Group Head–Consumer
Lifestyle and Leisure Brands, Restaurants, Automotive/E-commerce

Jon Andersen, CFA, Partner +1 312 364 8697
Consumer Products

Phillip Blee, CPA +1 312 801 7874
Home and Outdoor, Automotive Parts and Services, Discount and Convenience

Dylan Carden +1 312 801 7857
E-commerce, Specialty Retail

ECONOMICS

Richard de Chazal, CFA +44 20 7868 4489

ENERGY AND POWER TECHNOLOGIES

Jed Dorsheimer +1 617 235 7555
Group Head–Energy and Power Technologies
Generation, Efficiency, Storage

Neal Dingmann +1 312 801 7835
Oil and Gas, Rare Earth

Tim Mulrooney, Partner +1 312 364 8123
Energy and Environmental Services

FINANCIAL SERVICES AND TECHNOLOGY

Adam Klauber, CFA, Partner +1 312 364 8232
Group Head–Financial Services and Technology
Financial Analytic Service Providers, Insurance Brokers, Property & Casualty Insurance

Andrew W. Jeffrey, CFA +1 415 796 6896
Fintech

Cristopher Kennedy, CFA +1 312 364 8596
Fintech, Specialty Finance

Jeff Schmitt +1 312 364 8106
Wealthtech, Wealth Management, Capital Markets Technology

GLOBAL SERVICES

Tim Mulrooney, Partner +1 312 364 8123
Group Head–Global Services
Commercial and Residential Services

Andrew Nicholas, CPA +1 312 364 8689
Consulting, HR Technology, Information Services

Trevor Romeo, CFA +1 312 801 7854
Staffing, Waste and Recycling

HEALTHCARE

Biotechnology

Matt Phipps, Ph.D., Partner +1 312 364 8602
Group Head–Biotechnology

Sami Corwin, Ph.D. +1 312 801 7783

Lachlan Hanbury-Brown +1 312 364 8125

Andy T. Hsieh, Ph.D., Partner +1 312 364 5051

Myles R. Minter, Ph.D., Partner +1 617 235 7534

Scott Hansen, Partner Associate Director of Research +1 212 245 6526

Healthcare Technology and Services

Ryan S. Daniels, CFA, Partner +1 312 364 8418
Group Head–Healthcare Technology and Services
Healthcare Technology, Healthcare Services

Steven Lichtman +1 646 561 9373
Medical Technology

Brandon Vazquez, CFA +1 212 237 2776
Dental, Animal Health, Medical Technology

Life Sciences

Matt Larew, Partner +1 312 801 7795
Life Science Tools, Bioprocessing, Healthcare Delivery

Andrew F. Brackmann, CFA +1 312 364 8776
Diagnostics

Max Smock, CFA +1 312 364 8336
Pharmaceutical Outsourcing and Services

INDUSTRIALS

Brian Drab, CFA, Partner +1 312 364 8280
Co-Group Head–Industrials
Advanced Manufacturing, Industrial Technology

Ryan Merkel, CFA, Partner +1 312 364 8603
Co-Group Head–Industrials
Building Products, Specialty Distribution

Louie DiPalma, CFA, Partner +1 312 364 5437
Aerospace and Defense, Smart Infrastructure

Ross Sparenblek +1 312 364 8361
Diversified Industrials, Robotics, and Automation

TECHNOLOGY, MEDIA, AND COMMUNICATIONS

Jason Ader, CFA, Partner +1 617 235 7519
Co-Group Head–Technology, Media, and Communications
Infrastructure Software

Arjun Bhatia, Partner +1 312 364 5696
Co-Group Head–Technology, Media, and Communications
Software

Dylan Becker, CFA +1 312 364 8938
Software

Louie DiPalma, CFA, Partner +1 312 364 5437
Government Technology

Jonathan Ho, Partner +1 312 364 8276
Cybersecurity, Security Technology

Patrick McIlwee, CFA +1 312 364 8655
Software

Sebastien Naji +1 212 245 6508
Infrastructure Software, Semiconductor and Infrastructure Systems

Maggie Nolan, CPA, Partner +1 312 364 5090
IT Services

Ralph Schackart III, CFA, Partner +1 312 364 8753
Internet and Digital Media

Stephen Sheldon, CFA, CPA, Partner +1 312 364 5167
Vertical Technology – Real Estate, Education, Restaurant/Hospitality

EDITORIAL AND SUPERVISORY ANALYSTS

Steve Goldsmith, Head Editor and SA +1 312 364 8540
Katie Anderson, Editor and SA +44 20 7868 4451
Audrey Majors, Editor and SA +1 312 364 8992
Beth Pekol Porto, Editor and SA +1 312 364 8924
Lisa Zurcher, Editor and SA +44 20 7868 4549